

THE SECOND GLASS

Written by

Written by

James & Maya – a oner

Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.  
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FADE IN:

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - NIGHT

Black. Then rooftops – the flat blue dark of a cul-de-sac asleep.

The camera hangs high above one house. A single downstairs window burns gold against all that blue.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, unhurried, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open an inch –

INT. HOUSE - KITCHEN / LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

– and into the warmth.

A kettle ticks as it cools. Two mugs wait on the counter. One steams. One is stone cold.

MAYA, 30s, coat still on, stands at the island. Her phone lies face-down under her flat palm, pinned there. Everything about her day is finished except this.

JAMES, 30s, is at the counter with a tea towel, drying a plate. He has been drying the same plate for some time.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. But something in him eases – the small give of a body that has decided it isn't alone.

MAYA

I moved the seven o'clock.

JAMES

You didn't have to do that.

MAYA

I know I didn't have to. That's the – I rearranged my entire night so we could sit in a room and be two people, and you're doing the dishes.

JAMES

It's one plate.

MAYA  
It's been one plate for twenty  
minutes.

He looks at the plate like someone just put it in his hands.  
Sets it down.

MAYA (CONT'D)  
You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES  
Did I.

MAYA  
Two. I watched you. You drank one  
and you poured the other one down  
the sink. A full mug. And you  
weren't even upset about it –  
that's the part. You did it like it  
was the most normal thing in the  
world.

JAMES  
I made too much.

MAYA  
You don't make too much. You  
measure the rice, James. You weigh  
it. You have never once in six  
years made too much of anything.

He picks up the cold mug. Slides it two inches left. Squares  
it against nothing. Doesn't notice he's done it.

MAYA (CONT'D)  
I've stopped asking who's coming  
over.

JAMES  
Nobody's coming over.

MAYA  
I know. I've found the good glasses  
out. I've come down to the table  
set for a dinner that was the two  
of us. I stopped asking because the  
answer was making me feel insane,  
so now I just – clock it, and I put  
the extra one back in the cupboard,  
and I don't say anything.

JAMES  
I like the house nice.

MAYA  
You like the house ready. It's a  
different thing. You keep it ready  
like a waiting room.

He crosses to the back door. Opens it. Cold pours in. He  
props it with his heel, then his foot, then just – leaves  
it. An inch. Like the window.

MAYA (CONT'D)  
It's November.

JAMES  
It gets close in here.

The camera drifts a slow, low arc between them. James's eyes  
go with it. Not to her. To it. To the empty air where it  
moves.

Maya watches him watch nothing at all.

MAYA  
There. You just left.

JAMES  
I'm standing right here.

MAYA  
Say my name.

JAMES  
What?

MAYA  
Say my name. Right now. Without  
looking for it first.

A beat. His head turns – a fraction, toward the space beside  
him – before it comes back to her.

JAMES  
Maya.

MAYA  
You had to find me first.

Silence. The kettle ticks.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I used to think I could out-wait it. Whatever it is. I told myself, be patient, he's carrying something, and if I'm good enough and quiet enough and I don't make it worse, one day he'll set it down and turn around and I'll be standing there.

JAMES

Don't.

MAYA

I made myself so easy to be married to that I stopped being in the marriage. I disappeared to give you room. And the room was never for me.

JAMES

You want all of me.

MAYA

I want any of you. I'd take any of you.

JAMES

(beat)

There isn't all of me. There's what's left over. I told you that. At the start — I told you what this was, and you married what was left over, and now you're standing in my kitchen furious that it isn't more.

The words land. She doesn't flinch. That's the frightening part.

She takes her hand off the phone. Picks it up. The tell that she's done.

MAYA

I made myself smaller so there'd be room for me. Do you hear how that — I made myself smaller to fit into the space where I already was.

The wall comes down. One second. Her whole face, open, unarmed.

Then she reaches up and does a coat button that was already done. And it's back. Brick by brick, in real time — the most honest thing she does all night.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Anyway.

He crosses the room to her. Fast, for him. He lifts a hand toward her face. It's real. For one second the whole thing could stop here.

The camera slides into the edge of the frame.

His eyes flick to it. Half a second. No more.

She sees the flick.

MAYA (CONT'D)

(quiet)

No. Don't do the one where you almost.

She steps back out of his reach.

A beat. When she speaks again the case is gone from her voice – no evidence, no counting. Just the plain thing, finally said.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I kept trying to catch you being cruel. It would have been easier to leave a cruel man. You were never cruel. You've just been somewhere I was never going to be invited, and I'm tired of standing in the doorway of it, being reasonable.

JAMES

Maya –

MAYA

Lock the door after me. Both of them. The seven-thirty's real.

She doesn't move for it. They both know she doesn't have to go. She goes anyway.

The camera does not follow her.

It stays with James. The front door opens off-frame. A wash of cold. It clicks shut.

Silence, except the kettle, ticking down to nothing.

James stands alone in the middle of the room. His hand comes up, slow, and hangs in the air beside him – palm open, at a height, as if to rest on a shoulder that should be there.

The camera drifts into that space. Right into it. Fills the place where his hand is reaching. Warm. Familiar. Waiting to be touched.

His fingers are an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. Really sees it – sees what he's doing, sees the reach, sees the room, sees the two mugs and the extra glass and the open door and the whole shape of the evening laid out like evidence.

His face breaks.

JAMES (CONT'D)  
(barely)  
No.

He steps back from it.

JAMES (CONT'D)  
No. Not – not now. Not tonight.

The camera follows him. Gentle. It doesn't understand. It comes closer.

JAMES (CONT'D)  
(a roar, ragged, at the  
empty air)  
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS – a hard rush back, away from him, across the room, low over the counter, past the cold mug, out through the gap in the window where it came –

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

– out into the cold and UP, fast, climbing hard, the gold window shrinking beneath it.

It stops, high above the roof, and looks down.

Down at the little lit house. Down at the one warm window with the man standing in it, small now, both hands over his face.

The camera holds there in the dark, tilted down – the way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.